

Lesson 19

Giving Concise Updates



Warm-Up

1. Based on your experience, what do you think is the biggest challenge in giving project updates?
2. What strategies do you use to ensure that project updates are clear and concise?





Role-Play

Scenario: John, a project manager, needs to give a project update to his team member, Alex, on the project's progress.

Version 1: Unclear Update

John: Hey Alex, I just wanted to let you know that we're working on some stuff, and it's going okay, I guess. We'll get it done eventually.

Alex: *(looks confused)* What do you mean by 'some stuff'? **To keep it brief**, which tasks are we talking about? And what's the deadline? Could you please **summarize** the **key points** for all the tasks?

Version 2: Concise Update

John: Hey Alex, just a quick update to **outline the progress** of the project's tasks. We've completed tasks A and B and we're on track to finish task C by Friday. However, we're experiencing a delay with task D. **The key issue is** miscommunication with the design team, which might impact our overall deadline.

Alex: *(nods)* Got it, thanks for the update. What's the plan to address the delay with task D?

Role-Play Analysis

Answer the following questions:

1. How did Alex respond differently to the two updates?
2. What are the benefits of providing concise updates?
3. How can you apply this to your own project updates?
4. What are common pitfalls to avoid when providing updates?



Practice

Activity 1: Role-Play Exercise

Instructions: Supply the missing key vocabulary with the key words and phrases below.

to keep it brief...	the key issue...	key points
summarize		outline the progress

Scenario: *James is managing a software development project, and he is giving an update to the project owner, Henry.*

Henry: Can you give me an update on the project?

James: To _____ the current project status, I'd like to highlight the following _____: we've completed the coding phase and are moving forward with testing.

Henry: That's great to hear. What's the biggest challenge you're facing right now?

James: _____ that we're experiencing some technical difficulties with the new API integration, which might impact our timeline.

Henry: Okay, I understand. Can you give me a quick overview of the new project's progress?

James: To _____, we've made significant advancements in the past quarter and are on track to meet our deadline. _____, I'll focus on the main points and avoid unnecessary details.

Activity 2: Rewrite Unclear Project Update

Directions: Rewrite the unclear project update below to make it more professional and concise.

Scenario 1: An employee providing updates to the team leader.

Context:

- Initial set-up has been completed.
- Encountered a delay caused by the lack of supplier coordination.

Unclear Update: “Hey, we’ve been doing some things lately. I think we’re fine, but there were a few problems with some things so it’s a bit messy.”

Scenario 2: A team leader providing updates to the project manager.

Context:

- The project is on track.
- The main issue is the limited budget.
- A progress report will be prepared once the budget discussion with the finance team is finalized.

Unclear Update: “Everything’s okay, but there’s a thing with the budget. Not sure what’s going to happen. We might need to change some parts.”

Scenario 3: An employee providing updates to the team leader.

Context:

- The testing was completed.
- Currently working on the development phase
- The key issue is the unexpected bug affecting login features; currently working on the bug and the project is still on track.

Unclear Update: “Yeah, things are happening. We did some stuff last week, and now we’re doing more. Something didn’t go well, but I think we’ll figure it out.”



Production

Instructions:

1. Work in pairs.
2. **Student A** will ask **Student B** for an update on the project.
3. **Student B** will give a concise update, focusing on the main points and avoiding unnecessary details.
4. **Student A** may ask follow-up questions or request clarification.
5. **Student B** will respond to their questions and provide additional information as needed.



Key Vocabulary

Word/Phrase	Use	Example
Summarize	Used to provide a brief and concise overview of the main points, ideas, or key information of a larger work or situation.	To summarize , we've made significant progress on the project, completing phase 1 and 2, and on track to meet the deadline.
Key points	This refers to the most important, relevant, and essential information, ideas, or facts about a particular topic, project, or situation.	The key points from this week's progress are completion of phase 1, identification of potential roadblocks, and adjustments to the project timeline.
Outline progress	Used in summarizing and highlighting the advancements, achievements, and milestones reached in a project, task, or activity.	To outline progress , we've completed phases 1 and 2, and are currently working on phase 3, with a project completion date of April 15 th .

The key issue is...	Used to focus on the most critical information and to prioritize the most important issue that needs to be addressed.	The key issue is that we're experiencing delays in the development phase, which may impact on our ability to meet the deadline.
To keep it brief...	Used to provide a brief and focused update.	To keep it brief, I've completed the design phase and am moving on to testing.



Homework

- ✓ **Format:** Audio recording.
- ✓ **Duration:** 1-3 minutes
- ✓ **Deadline:**

To help you feel more confident and prepared when giving concise updates, answer the following questions.

1. In giving concise updates, why is summarizing key points important?
2. Depending on the context and complexity of information, what is the ideal number of key points?
3. How are you going to summarize complex information?